

DOCUMENT 46

EXECUTIVE MEETING & \$100K+ SPONSORSHIP CLOSING PLAYBOOK

Discovery • Executive Positioning • Major Ask • Objections • Proposal • Negotiation • Approval • Close

Purpose: Govern high-value corporate meetings and major sponsorship opportunities created by the 90-day \$1 million campaign. This playbook is designed for qualified conversations where a prospect may have the capacity and strategic fit for a significant partnership.

Planning principle: A \$100K+ sponsorship is not closed by pressure. It is built by understanding the sponsor's priorities, connecting those priorities to a credible program opportunity, recommending a specific partnership, navigating internal approval and following through professionally.

DO NOT ASK: "HOW MUCH CAN YOU GIVE US?" BUILD THE CASE, THEN RECOMMEND THE PARTNERSHIP.

1. WHEN THIS PLAYBOOK APPLIES

- A Top 25 / Tier A prospect agrees to meet.
- A prospect indicates potential support of approximately \$50K or more.
- A company asks for a formal proposal, executive presentation or sponsorship options.
- A warm introduction reaches a senior corporate decision-maker.
- A strategic partner discusses naming, exclusivity, major activation, employee engagement, media, data, scholarships or multi-year support.

2. THE 24-HOUR PRE-MEETING BRIEF

Brief Element	Required Preparation
Company	What it does; NY/community footprint; current relevant public priorities.
Attendees	Name, title, likely influence, decision authority and relationship to budget.
Why us / why now	Three sentences connecting the Challenge to verified priorities.
Primary recommendation	Exact planning ask and what it enables.
Secondary recommendation	Lower cash level or strategically useful hybrid option.
Evidence	Only verified program facts, participation information and approved materials.
Questions	5-8 discovery questions tailored to this company.
Likely objection	Budget, timing, geography, scale, measurement, fit, legal or activation.
Desired outcome	Specific next step: proposal, second meeting, internal introduction, application path, etc.
Leadership roles	Who opens, discovers, presents, asks, takes notes and closes next steps.

3. WHO SHOULD ATTEND

Role	Meeting Function
Founder / Executive	Vision, credibility, relationship, major recommendation, strategic negotiation.
Fellow / Account Owner	Research context, relationship history, notes, CRM continuity and follow-up.
Program Lead, when needed	Program mechanics, student experience, implementation and measurable outcomes.
Operations / Finance, later stage	Agreement, invoicing/donation process, fulfillment and reporting.

Do not crowd the first meeting. Two or three prepared people are usually stronger than a large internal audience.

4. THE 30-MINUTE EXECUTIVE MEETING

Time	Phase	Objective
0-3 min	Relationship & context	Thank them; establish why the conversation matters.
3-7 min	Founder vision	Explain the Challenge and the problem it is designed to solve.
7-18 min	Discovery	Understand priorities, audience, budget ownership, timing, outcomes and constraints.
18-23 min	Partnership bridge	Connect what you heard to a tailored partnership concept.
23-27 min	Recommendation / ask	Present the appropriate partnership level when enough information exists.
27-30 min	Next step	Agree on owner, deliverable and date.

5. FOUNDER OPENING — 60 TO 90 SECONDS

The founder should sound like the builder of a serious youth initiative, not someone arriving simply to request money. The opening should establish the mission, explain the real-world student experience and then turn the conversation toward the company.

Suggested structure: “We created the Student Impact Challenge to give young people something education often cannot provide by itself: the experience of walking into their communities, speaking with real businesses, identifying real problems and developing solutions. We want students to build confidence, entrepreneurship, communication and future-ready skills by doing—not just hearing about them. We’re speaking with a small group of organizations whose priorities genuinely connect to that mission, which is why I wanted to learn more about what matters most to your team before we discuss what a partnership could look like.”

6. DISCOVERY QUESTIONS THAT CREATE THE CLOSE

- What youth, education, workforce or community outcomes matter most to your organization right now?
- How does your team typically evaluate partnerships like this?
- Is this primarily a community-impact, foundation, marketing, workforce, education or corporate-affairs decision?
- What would make a partnership meaningful enough internally to receive serious consideration?
- Are there specific New York communities, student populations or program themes that are priorities?
- What types of employee engagement, mentorship or experiential components are most valuable?
- How do you prefer impact to be measured and reported?
- What is the normal budget and approval timeline for a partnership of this nature?
- Who else should be involved before we develop a proposal?
- If there is alignment, what would you need from us to move this forward?

7. LISTEN FOR BUYING SIGNALS

Signal	Examples / Interpretation
Strong	“Send us a proposal.” / “What sponsorship levels are available?” / “We should bring in our foundation/marketing lead.”
Medium	“This aligns with our priorities.” / “Can you send more information?” / “What would our involvement look like?”
Weak	General compliments with no process, owner, timing or next action.
Negative	No eligibility, closed budget with no alternative, geographic mismatch, no strategic fit or explicit decline.

8. WHEN TO MAKE THE \$100K-\$250K ASK

Make a specific recommendation when you understand enough about the prospect's priorities, decision process and likely capacity to explain why the level makes sense. It may happen in the first meeting or after discovery. Do not force the number simply because the account was originally assigned a large planning ask.

Recommended transition: “Based on what you've shared—particularly your focus on [priority]—I believe the strongest fit would be for [Company] to come in as a major partner at \$150,000. That would allow us to [approved outcomes/activation]. We can also structure a \$75,000 pathway if that better matches the current budget. Would it be useful for us to put those options into a concise proposal for your team?”

9. WHAT THE ASK MUST ANSWER

Question	Answer Required
Why this company?	Direct connection to verified corporate priorities.
Why this amount?	Level tied to real program scope/activation—not corporate wealth alone.
What does it enable?	Approved program outcomes, access, scholarships, experiences, reach or activation.
What does sponsor receive?	Only approved recognition/engagement benefits.
How is impact measured?	Defined reporting that can actually be produced.
What happens next?	Proposal, review, internal approval, agreement and onboarding.

10. HIGH-VALUE OBJECTION PLAYBOOK

Objection	Response Strategy
"\$150K is too much."	Do not immediately discount. Ask what range is realistic. Re-scope the partnership. "Understood. Is the issue the overall budget, this year's timing, or the level relative to the activation? We can structure a meaningful \$75K pathway if that is closer to your current range."
"We only have \$25K."	If strategically worthwhile, accept the reality and design a \$25K partnership. Do not lose a strong sponsor because the original planning ask was larger. Explore expansion next cycle.
"Our budget is closed."	Ask when the next cycle opens, whether another department has a current budget, and whether a smaller/in-kind activation can establish the relationship now.
"We can donate products, not cash."	Evaluate the true usefulness and fair value. Keep in-kind separate. Ask whether a cash component is possible or whether the product contribution can support a specific need.
"Send us a proposal."	Confirm priorities, amount/range if possible, decision-makers, deadline and required format before drafting.
"What visibility do we get?"	Discuss only approved benefits and ask what visibility matters to them. Never invent media coverage, exclusivity or audience numbers.
"Can we be exclusive?"	Do not agree in the room. Clarify category/scope/duration requested and escalate for leadership/legal review.
"Can we access participant data?"	Do not promise it. Explain that participant privacy and applicable consent rules govern any data sharing; escalate the request.
"Can you guarantee media?"	Only guarantee media placements the program directly controls and has approved. Do not guarantee independent editorial coverage.
"Can we meet the students?"	Explore an approved, supervised program activation consistent with student safety, consent and program rules.

11. NEGOTIATION BOUNDARIES

- Never negotiate participant/student personal data as a sponsorship benefit.
- Never promise exclusivity, naming rights, celebrity access, guaranteed media, political access or unapproved benefits without authorization.
- Never misstate tax deductibility; the appropriate organization/finance/legal process must determine documentation.
- Never inflate participation, impressions, reach, scholarship value or impact.
- Never combine cash and in-kind to make a cash close appear larger.
- Never sign or accept legal terms outside authorized authority.
- Never let urgency force the program into a benefit it cannot fulfill.

12. PROPOSAL TRANSITION

A proposal should reflect what was learned in discovery. It should not be a generic deck with the company name changed. For a \$100K+ opportunity, include: executive summary; why the partnership fits; proposed investment; what the investment enables; sponsor activation/recognition; timeline; measurable outcomes; reporting; roles; optional secondary level; and next-step process.

13. PROPOSAL FOLLOW-UP CADENCE

Timing	Action
Same day	Thank-you email; summarize agreed priorities and next step.
Within 24-72 hours	Deliver proposal if promised and sufficient information is available.
2-3 business days after proposal	Confirm receipt; ask whether questions emerged.
5-7 business days	Substantive follow-up tied to decision process.
Agreed internal date	Follow up on the date the prospect gave you.
If delayed	Ask for a new decision date rather than sending repeated generic check-ins.

14. VERBAL INTEREST IS NOT CLOSED MONEY

Stage	Meaning
Interest	Positive reaction; no commitment.
Defined Opportunity	Specific need/ask/process/timing exists.
Proposal	Formal recommendation delivered.
Approval	Specific support moving through internal decision/procurement.
Verbal / Intent	Sponsor indicates intention, subject to documentation/approval.
Confirmed	Meets the program's approved confirmation standard.
Cash Received	Funds actually received and recorded.
Activated	Sponsor onboarding/benefits/fulfillment underway.

15. PROCUREMENT, LEGAL & PAYMENT

Major sponsors may require vendor/nonprofit onboarding, W-9 or tax documentation, charitable-status documentation, insurance, agreements, brand guidelines, purchase orders, invoicing, ACH setup, compliance review or other corporate processes. Assign one operations owner. Do not let a verbal yes die because paperwork has no owner.

16. THE CLOSING QUESTION

When the prospect has indicated alignment and the proposal has been addressed, ask for the decision professionally: “Is there anything remaining that would prevent us from moving forward with the \$150,000 partnership as proposed?” If they identify an obstacle, solve the obstacle. If not, ask for the exact approval/documentation next step and date.

17. IF THEY GO SILENT AFTER A GREAT MEETING

Action	Rule
First follow-up	Reference the agreed next step, not merely “checking in.”
Second follow-up	Add a useful answer/update connected to their priorities.
Third follow-up	Ask whether timing changed and whether a new decision date is appropriate.
Executive nudge	Use only when relationship/size warrants it; do not overwhelm the prospect.
Nurture	If no active decision path remains, remove from late-stage pipeline and preserve relationship.

18. FIRST 30 DAYS AFTER A MAJOR YES

Timing	Action
Day 0-2	Thank sponsor; complete confirmation/agreement/payment process; assign sponsor owner.
Day 1-5	Kickoff call; confirm benefits, brand assets, activation, contacts, timeline and reporting.
Week 1	Internal fulfillment checklist; student/privacy/safety review where relevant.
Week 2	Confirm first visible deliverable or activation milestone.
Week 3	Provide concise progress communication.
Week 4	30-day sponsor check-in; confirm satisfaction, upcoming milestones and unresolved items.

19. EXECUTIVE MEETING SCORECARD

Factor	Points
Preparation / research	15
Founder/program story	10
Discovery quality	20
Listening / sponsor understanding	10
Partnership fit	15
Ask quality / confidence	10
Objection handling	5
Clear next step	10

Factor	Points
CRM / follow-up discipline	5
TOTAL	100

20. THE \$1 MILLION CLOSING PRINCIPLE

The objective is not to convince every company. It is to find the organizations where the mission genuinely aligns, create a partnership worthy of a meaningful investment, make the recommendation confidently, and manage the corporate decision process until there is a clear yes, no or future date. Twenty well-managed major relationships can matter more than thousands of unqualified emails.

NEXT DOCUMENT

Document 47 — Major Sponsorship Proposal & \$100K-\$250K Partnership Architecture. This should define the actual structure of flagship, major and leadership sponsorship proposals: investment levels, what each level enables, benefits, activation options, measurement, reporting and customizable modules for different industries.

PROGRAM CONTACT

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